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POLITICO's must-read briefing on what's driving the day in Brussels, by Gerardo Fortuna, Nicholas Vinocur and Gabriel Gavin. By GERARDO FORTUNA COUCOU

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COUCOU, THERE: Gerardo Fortuna with you, testing your French skills this morning ahead of Commission chief Ursula von der Leyen's speech to entrepreneurs in Paris, which will be delivered — unusually — entirely en français, one EU official tells Playbook. The main topic? Mais bien sûr: la compétitivité!

In today's Playbook:

- Friedrich Merz lunches with budget hawks today, with cuts in EU spending on the menu.
- Brussels' night-train map expands. Next stop: Milan.
- Faces in the crowd: Bjoern Seibert, John Ratcliffe, Mario Draghi, Roberta Metsola, Petteri Orpo, Ilze Juhansone, Andy Burnham, Kaja Kallas, Christian Stocker, Gabriel Attal and Stéphane Séjourné, Emmanuel Macron, Anna-Kaisa Ikonen, António Costa, Andrej Babiš and many more.

On today's Brussels Playbook Podcast: Zoya and Katie discuss Mark Carney's upcoming trip to the EU to listen to Ursula von der Leyen's big speech — and drum up support from a fellow middle power.

DRIVING THE DAY

MAKE YOUR PLAY: The battle over what makes it into Ursula von der Leyen's State of the European Union speech is entering the final stretch, with the Commission's most powerful aides preparing a lobbying push at a secluded gathering, five officials told Playbook.

Chiefs' rentrée: Commission heads of cabinet are heading to Jodoigne in Wallonia tomorrow for a special, day-long edition of their weekly hebdo meeting, chaired by Secretary-General Ilze Juhansone. AI and several other files are on the agenda — along with a mystery guest.

The real business: The gathering gives chiefs of staff a chance to get in the ear of Bjoern Seibert, von der Leyen's powerful head of cabinet and one of the key figures shaping the Commission president's Sept. 16 Strasbourg address (which is already being drafted).

The pitch: “Some people will address the top priorities for them ... or maybe pitch new ideas,” one official said. They were granted anonymity, like the others quoted here, to discuss internal tactics.

Making the cut: The EU’s new security strategy, a climate comeback (just don’t call it the Green Deal!), restrictions on children’s social media use and a revamped mandate for Frontex are all expected to feature in the speech, officials told Playbook.

Why it matters: Even a passing mention in the SOTEU can propel a file up the Commission’s political pecking order, which is why cabinets are seizing their chance to secure a place in the sun for their policies. But it’s a zero-sum game: There’s only so much room in a speech.

Missed your chance? Commissioners will also be able to push their pet projects when they sit down with von der Leyen for the traditional college seminar in Tervuren next week, which kicks off the political season. “She usually gets things from her direct conversations with commissioners,” a second official said, referring to topics that make it into the speech.

Marking the day: Mark Carney has accepted von der Leyen’s invitation to attend the September address , Gabriel Gavin reports. The Canadian PM will address the Parliament the following day.

Group therapy check-in: Tomorrow’s gathering will also be a chance to discuss whether relations inside the Commission have improved since the start of von der Leyen’s second mandate, three officials said.

Rewind: Playbook readers will remember the internal spats — including that commissioner shouting match — that triggered a rethink of how von der Leyen’s second Commission works. The response to the tension was to give commissioners more ownership of their dossiers and reduce the executive vice presidents’ role in overseeing their work.

The verdict: Mixed — with one official seeing little fundamental change. “There will always be clashes because of the [College’s] political composition,” they said. Another said relations had “clearly” improved — although that may be a result of commissioners and their cabinets working better together, rather than because of the new internal rules.

BIG AND BREAKING

NEPAL FLASH FLOODING: At least 165 people have been killed in Nepal by flash floods and a mudslide, with 403 tourists missing, according to overnight reports .

RATCLIFFE’S WARNING: CIA Director John Ratcliffe used his Moscow visit this week to warn Russian officials not to escalate conflict with America’s NATO allies , in particular Estonia, Latvia and Lithuania, my colleagues in Washington scooped overnight.

PUTIN’S NEXT MOVE: Meanwhile, France’s chief of defense staff is warning of more “violent, hostile action” as Russia intensifies its hybrid war in Europe, pointing to the explosive device found near a Ukrainian cargo plane in Leipzig.

FRANCE’S IMPERILED MODERATES: Centrist candidates in France’s presidential race are looking rudderless ahead of the first major debate today, with rivals on the political extremes setting the terms on how to fix the country’s finances, Clea Caulcutt reports.

EU TAKES TO THE BOTTLE: First Brussels came for the bottle caps ... Now, glassmakers fear EU anti-waste rules are coming for the bottles themselves, spelling trouble for the fancy glass designs that

help make your Tanqueray look like Tanqueray.

MACRON'S U.K. VISIT: Andy Burnham hosts Emmanuel Macron in Downing Street next week, officially for the opening of the Bayeux Tapestry exhibition but with a "reset" of London's relationship with the EU on the agenda.

A FRUGAL LUNCH

BUDGET CUTS ON THE MENU: German Chancellor Friedrich Merz has invited leaders who share his desire to shrink the EU's next seven-year budget to Berlin for a lunch ... and to plot their next move , Gregorio Sorgi reports with our EU politics team.

Penny-pinchers strike back: The meeting with Austria, Finland, the Netherlands and Denmark — plus Sweden, which will dial in — comes at a sensitive time in the negotiations. European Council President António Costa is touring European capitals to lay the ground for a budget deal, while the Brussels machine cranks back into action after the summer.

Can you put a figure on it? The German-led group is poised to demand cuts to the tune of "hundreds of billions of euros" from the Commission's €2 trillion budget proposal, Austrian Chancellor Christian Stocker told my Berlin Playbook colleague Hans von der Burchard. However, their joint statement won't include a specific figure, according to three officials with knowledge of proceedings, granted anonymity to discuss the plans.

Their message will emphasize "modernization" — including steering money away from agriculture and regional payouts towards defense and security — and strong links between payments and democratic safeguards, said two of the officials.

"Not every line item in the budget automatically deserves a second term. Throwing money at problems doesn't solve a single one of them," Stocker said. Finnish Prime Minister Petteri Orpo struck a more positive note earlier this week, saying "the general priorities of the proposal are worthy of support" but the overall amount is too high.

The trickiest issue: The group is also set to compare notes over which new EU-wide taxes, or "own resources," it's ready to support, one official said.

Costa's barnstorming: The European Council president is set to tackle the same issues today during a meeting with Czech Prime Minister — and agriculture mogul — Andrej Babiš. Costa made another appeal Wednesday for countries to soften their stance on own resources. "The main priority now is to fix what kind of new own resources we can agree on," he said.

TALK TO PLAYBOOK: On the Brussels Playbook Podcast, Zoya asked you to write in with your favorite iconic bottle. Whatsapp us on +32 491 050629 and listen from 7 a.m. to hear if we give you a shoutout.

5 MORE THINGS GETTING US TALKING

NOT BROADSIDED: Mario Draghi's new venture may have surprised some in the Berlaymont but not Ursula von der Leyen, who was briefed by the former ECB president and even invited to the Rhine Group's first meeting, a Commission spokesperson told Playbook after checking internally.

VIKTOR WHO? Hungary has declared Russia a threat and backed Ukraine's territorial integrity — quite the departure from the Orbán years.

MOROCCO TURNS UP THE HEAT: A Moroccan minister used a ceremony attended by King Mohammed VI to invoke "liberating the occupied cities" — just as Pedro Sánchez may have hoped the Ceuta crisis was cooling.

BRAVA ROBERTA! Italian right-wing MEP Nicola Procaccini praised European President Roberta Metsola's "endorsement of Giorgia Meloni's call for common-sense solutions" — adding to speculation about an Italian-backed 2029 Metsola bid for the Commission.

ÉLYSÉE À DEUX: Gabriel Attal says his romantic partner, EU Commissioner Stéphane Séjourné, would move into the Élysée Palace with him if he were to win the French presidency.

BRUSSELS CORNER

WEATHER: Thundery showers mixed with sunshine. High of 29C.

NIGHT RIDER: Fall asleep in Brussels, wake up in Milan: You'll be able to do it from Sept. 9, when rail operator European Sleeper launches a new night train route linking the two cities. The 17-hour Brussels–Zurich–Milan service will run three times a week, stopping at Cologne, Zurich, Göschenen and Lugano before reaching Milano Porta Garibaldi. Antwerp, Breda and Eindhoven will also be added, starting December, with a night-train route to Scandinavia set to start operating from April 2028.

BREWERS' BELGIAN-PRIDE APPEAL: Belgian brewers launched a campaign against a new requirement to add the line "alcohol is harmful to health" to every booze ad, arguing the slogan will make people feel guilty about a part of Belgian heritage they should cherish.

"While France protects its wine as cultural heritage and Italy protects its Parma ham with pride, Belgium chooses to point the finger at its own tradition and national pride," the Belgian Brewers group said in an open letter. It wants the government to make a distinction between alcohol abuse and "enjoying responsibly."

Free will debate: Their petition got the support of centrist, liberal and center-right politicians, with CD&V President Sammy Mahdi telling De Standaard that "not everyone has to live on water and low-fat cheese." But Health Minister Frank Vandenbroucke defended the changes, saying while Belgians are known for their love of beer, "alcohol is harmful. And we all know that, really."

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TOP OF THE PLAYBOOKS

Berlin: The leaders of Germany's coalition parliamentary groups will take a stroll on the shore of Lake Aasee today with a clear aim: creating images of unity.

Paris: Seven presidential candidates will square off in this afternoon's debate organized by French entrepreneurs, but don't expect a love-in.

London: Andy Burnham is in South Wales today, hoping to strike the first spark of a Welsh Labour recovery to improve his chances of staying in No. 10.

Washington: Two Donald Trump-backed candidates triumphed in Republican primaries, with the president particularly relishing the defeat of Gentner Drummond in Oklahoma.

Canberra: Former Australian PM John Howard marks 25 years since the history-changing Tampa affair by taking a swipe at “sanctimonious Scandinavian countries.”

AGENDA

— European Commission President Ursula von der Leyen delivers a keynote speech at the annual La Rencontre des Entrepreneurs de France 2026 conference.

— European Council President António Costa is in Prague, where he meets Czech Prime Minister Andrej Babiš.

— EU foreign policy chief Kaja Kallas speaks at the Ambassadors Conference in Tallinn.

— Commission Executive Vice President Henna Virkkunen meets Finnish Minister of Local and Regional Government Anna-Kaisa Ikonen in Helsinki.

— Political and Security Committee meets in Brussels at 10 a.m.

— German Chancellor Friedrich Merz hosts EU leaders for a lunch on the next Multiannual Financial Framework and receives Norwegian Prime Minister Jonas Gahr Støre in the evening.

BIRTHDAYS

Former Austrian Chancellor and POLITICO 28 alum Sebastian Kurz; MEPs Dario Tamburrano and Ton Diepeveen; former MEPs Jane Brophy and Thomas Händel; France Inter’s Nora Hamadi.

Playbook is brought to you by POLITICO’s EU Politics team: Gerardo Fortuna, Nicholas Vinocur, Gabriel Gavin, Zoya Sheftalovich, Max Griera, Mari Eccles, Hanne Cokelaere and Sebastian Starcevic. And: reporters Milena Wälde and Daria Zakharova, editors Alex Spence and James Panichi, and producers Dean Southwell and Hugh Kapernaros.

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